

Ten Under Two Hundred

Ten short novels — funny, fast, and worth arguing about

Short novels that are genuinely funny and genuinely *about* something: comedies with a plot that moves, by writers worth an evening. Everything quiet, plotless or bleak has been filtered out. Each entry ends with the disagreement it will start in the room — that is the part worth reading before you choose. Ordered by strength of recommendation, not by date.

Candide — Voltaire

France · 1759 · ~120 pages

- Earthquakes, war, the Inquisition, El Dorado, a stolen sheep — the plot sprints and never once stops to catch its breath.
- Every catastrophe is played as farce; two and a half centuries on it is still faster and funnier than most things written this year.
- **The argument:** Is Pangloss's optimism idiocy, or the only way anyone survives what happens to them? And is "we must cultivate our garden" hard-won wisdom or a polite word for giving up?

Heart of a Dog — Mikhail Bulgakov

Russia · 1925 · ~130 pages

- A Moscow surgeon transplants human organs into a stray dog. The dog becomes a man, takes a job with the housing committee, and begins denouncing his creator to the authorities.
- Savage, hilarious, and structured like a door-slamming farce.
- **The argument:** Who is the monster — the creature, the professor who made him and then wanted him unmade, or the system that handed him a uniform and a grievance?

Botchan — Natsume Sōseki

Japan · 1906 · ~180 pages

- A hot-tempered young teacher from Tokyo is posted to a provincial school and immediately goes to war with his colleagues — nicknames, feuds, an ambush at the hot springs.

- Japan's best-loved comic novel, and the funniest book on this list.
- **The argument:** Is Botchan admirably incorruptible, or a fool who learns nothing and burns every bridge he crosses? Most groups split down the middle, and the split says a lot about the people in the room.

The Man Who Was Thursday — G.K. Chesterton

England · 1908 · ~180 pages

- A poet infiltrates a council of anarchists, each named for a day of the week — and then the twists begin and refuse to stop. Chases, duels, disguises, a hot-air balloon.
- Pure momentum for a hundred and fifty pages, then it turns metaphysical without warning.
- **The argument:** Does the ending pay off the chase or cheat it? What exactly is Sunday — God, nature, the universe, or Chesterton having a laugh at everyone who read this far?

Pnin — Vladimir Nabokov

USA · 1957 · ~180 pages

- A Russian émigré professor bumbles through an American college — wrong train, wrong lecture, wrong life.
- Nabokov gradually lets slip how much this ridiculous man has actually survived. The warmest book he ever wrote, and very funny before it stops being funny.
- **The argument:** Who is telling us this, and why does he keep turning up? Is the narrator's amusement affectionate, or is he doing to Pnin exactly what everyone else in the book does?

The Cloven Viscount — Italo Calvino

Italy · 1952 · ~110 pages

- A viscount is split clean in half by a cannonball. Both halves survive and go on living separately — one purely wicked, one unbearably good — until they meet for a duel over the same woman.
- A swashbuckler that takes about two hours to read.
- **The argument:** The good half causes nearly as much misery as the evil one. Is Calvino saying virtue without wholeness is its own kind of cruelty — and is anyone actually persuaded?

Tortilla Flat — John Steinbeck

USA · 1935 · ≈180 pages

- A gang of Monterey layabouts inherits two houses and proceeds to lose everything with enormous style — schemes, feuds, wine, a fire, a party that ends badly.
- Steinbeck retells it as a mock King Arthur legend, straight-faced, and the joke holds all the way to a genuinely weighty ending.
- **The argument:** Is Steinbeck celebrating these men or condescending to them? The Arthurian frame either ennobles them or quietly mocks them, and the book won't tell you which.

The Posthumous Memoirs of Brás Cubas — Machado de Assis

Brazil · 1881 · ≈200 pages

- Narrated by a dead man in 160 tiny chapters, several of which exist only to insult the reader.
- One of the funniest novels of the nineteenth century, from Brazil's greatest writer, and a formal experiment that predates everyone it supposedly influenced.
- **The argument:** He ends by tallying his life and concluding that his one real achievement was never having children. Is that the joke, or the verdict?

Burning Patience — Antonio Skármeta

*Chile · 1985 · ≈120 pages · also published as *The Postman**

- A postman on a Chilean island bribes, flatters and pesters Pablo Neruda into teaching him metaphors, so he can win the girl at the local inn.
- A proper courtship plot with real setbacks, very funny, and warm right up until history walks in at the end.
- **The argument:** Who owns a metaphor — the poet who made it or the man who finally had a use for it? And what is poetry actually worth on the day the soldiers arrive?

The Uncommon Reader — Alan Bennett

England · 2007 · ≈120 pages

- The Queen accidentally discovers reading, and her private secretary mounts a quiet conspiracy to stop her before it ruins everything.
- Brisk, comic, properly plotted, and it lands a real surprise on the final page.

- **The argument:** Reading makes her more thoughtful and much worse at her job. Does literature improve people, or does it simply unfit them for duty — and would your group accept that trade?

If you only pick one

- **Candid** — shortest, fastest, funniest, famous enough that nobody feels lectured, and the closing line has kept people arguing for 250 years.
- Runners-up by mood: *Heart of a Dog* if you want teeth, *Botchan* if you want laughter, *The Man Who Was Thursday* if you want to be gripped.

What got cut, and why

- Beautiful quiet books — *Foster*, *A Month in the Country*, *Our Souls at Night*, *Invisible Cities* — are wonderful alone and can die in a group, where half the room shrugs and says "nothing happened."
- *The Sense of an Ending* is the strongest discussion novel of the lot, but it is slow, melancholy, and has a suicide at its centre. Save it for later in the year, once people are comfortable enough to disagree out loud.

Worth breaking the page limit for

- All of these read faster than their length: Wodehouse, *Right Ho, Jeeves* (~230) · Forster, *A Room with a View* (~230) · von Arnim, *The Enchanted April* (~250) · Gibbons, *Cold Comfort Farm* (~230) · Calvino, *The Baron in the Trees* (~220).

Page counts are approximate and vary by edition.